

Google initiates PAIR to focus on 'human side' of AI

Google has now launched its all-new initiative called PAIR to study the ways people interact with AI. The latest move introduces open source tools to help researchers



develop new AI experiences.

"The goal of PAIR is to focus on the 'human side' of AI: the relationship between users and technology, the new applications it enables, and how to make it broadly inclusive," Google's senior staff

research scientists Martin Wattenberg and Fernanda Viégas wrote in a blog post.

Google is supporting machine learning and improving its position in the AI world, developing more accurate speech recognition, better image search and improved translations over a period of time. But since human interactions are vital to succeed with an AI system, the search giant has now been working on PAIR, which is Google's 'People + AI Research' approach.

Research using the PAIR approach will be broadly divided into three areas — engineers and researchers, domain experts, and everyday users. While engineering teams can leverage the latest initiative to simplify their AI developments through tools and guidelines, augmented reality professionals, doctors, technicians, designers, farmers and musicians will receive appropriate solutions through some operational PAIR research.

Google has dedicated a team of 12 engineers to kickstart developments under PAIR. It has also brought out open source visualisation tools to kickstart developer engagements for the newest initiative. Known as Facets Overview and Facets Dive, the two open source developments are specifically designed for AI engineers with an aim to 'address the very beginning' of machine learning. "The Facets applications give engineers a clear view of the data they use to train AI systems," PAIR researchers report.

Facet Overview takes input feature data from data sets to analyse them, feature by feature, and visualise the analysis. Facet Dive, on the other hand, helps to interactively explore a large number of data points at once.

The first open source Facet series is just beginning. Google has plans to release more open source tools in the future. Also, new grants and residencies will be set up to support AI research. Harvard researcher Prof. Brendan Meade and MIT expert Prof. Hal Abelson are also working with the PAIR team to intensify the developments.

Arduino gets Microsoft's Visual Studio Code Extension

Microsoft has released an extension of its Visual Studio Code for Arduino. The latest development will help hardware makers that are using Arduino to build their IoT (Internet of Things) projects.

With the arrival of the new Visual Studio Code Extension, Microsoft is apparently trying to address all the issues faced by IoT developers. The Visual Studio team at Microsoft has been closely working with developers to learn their pain points while

KDE Plasma 5.11 to feature a stable Snap backend

KDE Plasma desktop environment is all set to offer Snap backend support. The KDE team is in plans to bring a stable Snap backend for Plasma 5.11.

The currently available KDE Plasma 5.10 allows users to install applications with Snap and Flatpak package formats. The builds are shipped with the preview versions of the Snap and Flatpak backends. However, KDE engineers are expecting the Snap backend in its production environment at the time of the KDE Plasma 5.11 release in October this year.



In an official blog post, KDE's Aleix Pol said that the preview builds of Snap and Flatpak had been refactored to use the snapd-glib library. "During this sprint, it was refactored to use the snapd-glib library that should simplify the maintainership of this piece of software a bit. I am aiming to have a stable Snap backend for Plasma 5.11," said Pol, vice president at KDE e.V. Board.

Snap packages are used for distributing Linux apps. The universal binary format was first developed by Canonical for its own Ubuntu Linux operating system and later debuted across a range of Linux distributions. These packages look like the rest of the native apps that you would install on the KDE Plasma 5 desktop, but they will need a little bit of tweaking in terms of icons, styling and fonts.

The beta version of the KDE Plasma 5.11 desktop environment will be released on September 14. However, the final release milestone for KDE Plasma 5.11 is set for October 10. Users need to upgrade to the latest KDE Plasma to enjoy stable Snap support.